

Italian Artist's Banana Artwork Sells for \$6.2 Million

A much-publicized art piece made up of a single banana taped to a wall has sold for \$6.2 million.

The sale happened Wednesday night during an auction in New York City at famous art seller Sotheby's. The work, called Comedian, was sold to cryptocurrency businessman Justin Sun. He is a Chinese collector and founder of the cryptocurrency company Tron. Sun placed the winning bid over the phone and the sale was completed in cryptocurrency.

Before the auction, Sotheby's said the unusual art piece was expected to bring in at least \$1.5 million. But the price quickly started rising after the auction began, with people bidding inside the auction room, as well as on the phone and online.

The art piece had already sold three times for prices between \$120,000 and \$150,000, The Associated Press reported.

Sun said in a statement after the auction that Comedian "is not just an artwork." He added that the piece "bridges the worlds of art, memes, and the cryptocurrency community."

Sun said he planned to eat the banana, as at least two onlookers did when the artwork was presented at places around the world. Sotheby's says the fruit was always meant to be replaced repeatedly, along with the duct tape.

FILE - A man poses for a photo next to a banana attached with duct tape that replaces the artwork 'Comedian' by the artist Maurizio Cattelan, which was eaten by David Datuna, in Miami Beach, Florida, December 7, 2019. (REUTERS/Eva Marie Uzcategui)

The work was created by Italian artist Maurizio Cattelan. It was first presented in 2019 at the Art Basel Miami Beach show in Miami, Florida. The piece quickly led to much public discussion about what should be considered art.

Comedian belongs to a kind of art known as conceptual artwork. A conceptual piece is one in which the idea or meaning behind the work is more important than the finished object itself.

The head of contemporary art at Sotheby's is David Galperin. He told the AP he understands the piece's popularity because it is highly provocative. Provocative describes something likely to produce a strong reaction and much public debate.

"What Cattelan is really doing is turning a mirror to the contemporary art world," Galperin said. He added that he thinks Comedian can cause people to question what values should be attached to artworks and what can be defined as artwork.

“What you buy when you buy Cattelan’s Comedian is not the banana itself, but a certificate of authenticity,” Galperin said. That document, he added, gives the owner permission to reproduce the banana and duct tape on their own wall as an original artwork by the artist.

The sale of Comedian came shortly after Sotheby’s auctioned off a famed artwork in the Water Lilies series by French painter Claude Monet. That piece sold on Monday for \$65.5 million.

When asked to compare Cattelan's simple wall art to major works like Monet's, Galperin said that form of art, called impressionism, was not taken seriously when that movement first began.

“No important, profound, meaningful artwork of the past 100 years or 200 years, or our history for that matter, did not provoke some kind of discomfort when it was first unveiled,” Galperin said.

I’m Bryan Lynn.

The Associated Press reported this story. Bryan Lynn adapted the report for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

auction - n. การประมูลขายสาธารณะที่สิ่งของถูกขายให้กับผู้ที่เสนอราคาสูงสุด

comedian - n. ผู้ให้ความบันเทิงที่แสดงต่อหน้าผู้ชมและทำให้ผู้คนหัวเราะด้วยการเล่าเรื่องตลกหรือแสดงท่าทางตลก

bid - v. การเสนอราคาเพื่อซื้อบางสิ่งบางอย่าง

meme - n. ความคิด รูปภาพ วิดีโอ หรือสิ่งอื่น ๆ ที่แพร่กระจายอย่างรวดเร็วบนอินเทอร์เน็ต

duct tape - n. เทปกาชชนิดแข็งแรงมาก มักใช้สำหรับปิดรูหรือซ่อมแซมสิ่งของ

mirror - n. กระจกเงา แผ่นแก้วที่มีด้านหลังเคลือบโลหะเงาซึ่งสะท้อนแสงและสร้างภาพของสิ่งที่อยู่ข้างหน้า

certificate of authenticity - n. เอกสารรับรองความแท้ของงานศิลปะหรือสิ่งของ

original - adj. (ผลงาน) ต้นฉบับที่สร้างโดยศิลปินไม่ใช่สำเนา

profound - adj. ลึกซึ้ง, ซึ่งรู้สึกหรือประสบอย่างรุนแรงมาก หรือในระดับสุดขีด

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What was the final sale price of the art piece described as a banana taped to a wall?

- A. \$1.5 million
- B. \$120,000
- C. \$6.2 million

D. \$150,000

2. Who purchased the artwork named 'Comedian'?

- A. Sotheby's
- B. David Galperin
- C. Justin Sun
- D. Maurizio Cattelan

3. How was the payment for 'Comedian' completed by the buyer?

- A. With a bank transfer
- B. In physical cash
- C. Through an online bidding platform
- D. In cryptocurrency

4. What was Sotheby's initial expectation for the sale price of the art piece, prior to the auction?

- A. It was expected to sell for at least \$6.2 million.
- B. It was expected to sell for at least \$1.5 million.
- C. It was expected to sell for less than \$1 million.
- D. Sotheby's did not have an expectation for the price.

5. How many times had the art piece been sold previously, according to The Associated Press?

- A. Once
- B. Twice
- C. Three times
- D. Four times

6. According to Justin Sun, what broader connections does 'Comedian' bridge?

- A. Only the world of traditional art.
- B. The worlds of art, finance, and technology.
- C. The worlds of art, memes, and the cryptocurrency community.
- D. The worlds of commerce, entertainment, and social media.

7. What is the intended fate of the banana used in the artwork, according to Sotheby's?

- A. It is to be preserved indefinitely as part of the original artwork.
- B. It should be replaced repeatedly, along with the duct tape.

- C. It is meant to be eaten only by the artist, Maurizio Cattelan.
- D. It must be displayed in a special temperature-controlled environment.

8. Who is the artist behind the work 'Comedian'?

- A. Justin Sun
- B. David Galperin
- C. Claude Monet
- D. Maurizio Cattelan

9. What was the immediate public reaction when 'Comedian' was first presented?

- A. It was universally praised as a masterpiece.
- B. It caused immediate outrage and calls for its removal.
- C. It led to significant public discussion about the definition of art.
- D. It was largely ignored by the public and art critics.

10. What is the defining characteristic of a 'conceptual artwork' as described in the article?

- A. The physical object is always more important than its underlying idea.
- B. It always involves everyday objects like fruit and tape.
- C. The idea or meaning behind the work is more important than the finished object.
- D. It is exclusively sold to cryptocurrency investors.

11. Why does David Galperin, head of contemporary art at Sotheby's, believe 'Comedian' is popular?

- A. Because it is simple and easy to understand.
- B. Because it is highly provocative.
- C. Because it is a traditional form of art.
- D. Because it sold for an exceptionally high price.

12. According to Galperin, what does Cattelan's 'Comedian' prompt people to do?

- A. To buy more bananas and duct tape.
- B. To reject all forms of contemporary art.
- C. To question what values should be attached to artworks and what can be defined as artwork.
- D. To invest solely in cryptocurrency-related art.

13. When someone buys Cattelan's 'Comedian,' what tangible item are they primarily acquiring, according to Galperin?

- A. The specific banana and duct tape used by the artist.

- B. A replica of the original banana and tape.
- C. A certificate of authenticity that allows reproduction of the artwork.
- D. The intellectual property rights to the concept, preventing others from copying it.

14. What other significant artwork was auctioned by Sotheby's shortly before the sale of 'Comedian'?

- A. A painting from Vincent van Gogh's Starry Night series.
- B. A sculpture by Pablo Picasso.
- C. An artwork from the Water Lilies series by Claude Monet.
- D. A digital art piece by a cryptocurrency artist.

15. What general observation does David Galperin make about 'important, profound, meaningful artwork' when it is first unveiled?

- A. It is always immediately embraced and understood by the public.
- B. It rarely receives any public attention or debate.
- C. It often provokes some kind of discomfort.
- D. It is always a commercial success from the start.